

SELF-LOADING PISTOLS (1991–PRESENT)

Modern self-loading pistols differ little from their predecessors visually. However, their construction now involves an increased use of carbon composites, plastics, and lightweight metal alloys. Another key development is that their grips are designed to allow the use of high-capacity magazines capable of holding up to 20 rounds. The profile of the forward trigger guard bow has also become more vertical and grooved, a configuration that allows shooters to hold a pistol securely with both hands.



▲ COLT ALL AMERICAN 2000

Date 1991

Origin US

Barrel 4½in (11cm)

Caliber 9mm Parabellum

The All-American emerged from Colt in 1991, the brainchild of Reed Knight Jr. and Eugene Stoner. It was a 9mm gun with a frame made of either polymer or aluminum, hence it was extremely light. Colt ceased production of the gun in 1994.

Double-action trigger

Butt houses 15-round box magazine

Frame-mounted safety catch



Enlarged trigger guard

▲ HECKLER AND KOCH USP

Date 1993

Origin Germany

Barrel 4¼in (10.7cm)

Caliber 9mm Parabellum

The Universal Service Pistol (USP) was Heckler and Koch's answer to the Glock 17 (see p.266), and it, too, was largely made of plastic and employed the tried-and-tested Browning locking system. The USP could be configured in nine different ways—for instance, the trigger assemblies and magazines could be changed quickly.

Butt houses 10-round box magazine

Butt houses 17-round box magazine



▲ SIG-SAUER P226

Date 1991

Origin Switzerland

Barrel 4½in (11.5cm)

Caliber 9mm Parabellum

The SIG-Sauer P226 is a development of the SIG P220, one of the postwar period's finest semiautomatic handguns. The P226's higher-capacity magazines store up to 20 9mm Parabellum cartridges in a staggered column. This example is decorated with white gold, blue enamel, and 1,517 diamonds.

Vertical forward bow of trigger guard facilitates two-handed shooting



Rear sight

Ejector

▲ SMITH AND WESSON SIGMA

Date 1994

Origin US

Barrel 4in (10cm)

Caliber .40in Smith and Wesson

Smith and Wesson developed its Sigma pistol during 1993 and 1994. It features a frame made from a high-strength polymer and has an ergonomic grip containing a 17-round magazine. In common with some modern pistols, the frame has an integral accessory rail.